

# Outline of Roman History

## Legendary Foundations

**Aeneas** – is warrior from the city of Troy who fought in the Trojan War, according to Homer's Iliad. His father is a mortal named **Anchises**, but his mother is the goddess **Venus**. When the Greeks capture the city by hiding in the Trojan horse, he flees from burning Troy with his father Anchises, wife Creusa, son Iulus, and many followers. Creusa is lost as they leave the city. Their journey is long. They visit Carthage, where Aeneas falls in love with Queen Dido. When he believes his destiny calls him elsewhere, Dido pronounces a curse of conflict between Carthage and his future home. He arrives in Italy, where he marries Lavinia, the daughter of King Latinus. His son Iulus founds Alba Longa near the future site of Rome. After several generations, his descendants will populate Rome. Julius Caesar will trace his ancestry back to Iulus (from which the Julian gens, or family, gets their nomen) and therefore Venus.

**Romulus and Remus** – were twin sons of **Rhea Silvia** and **Mars**, many generations after Aeneas. Their grandfather, **Numitor**, was exiled by his evil brother **Amulius**. To make sure that Numitor would not have an heir, Amulius forced Numitor's daughter Rhea Silvia to become a Vestal Virgin, an unmarried maiden who would guard the sacred flame of Rome. That didn't stop Mars though, and so Romulus and Remus were born. Amulius exposed them in the wilderness so that they would die, but a she-wolf found them and nursed them as babies. Eventually they founded a city on the site of Rome in the region of **Latium**, through which the **Tiber** river runs. They argued over who should rule the city, and decide to look for a sign. They decided that each should watch for a sign of birds in flight, and whoever received the sign would rule. Each chose a hill to watch from. There are seven hills in Rome (**Aventine, Caelian, Capitoline, Esquiline, Palatine, Quirinal, and Viminal**). Romulus chose the Palatine and Remus the Aventine. Remus first saw six vultures flying overhead and believed he should rule; Romulus, however, later saw twelve vultures and thought this was surely a sign that he should rule. When they argued, Remus jumped over the small boundary Romulus had established on the Palatine, and Romulus killed him, thus becoming the first king of Rome.

## Monarchy (753 BCE – 509 BCE)

Rome is founded by Romulus on April 21, 753 BCE and ruled by a king, or monarch, with absolute power. The **Fasces** (bundle of rods with an axe) symbolized this imperium (power), representing the ability of the king to execute or beat his subjects

7 kings rule during the monarchy (~Roman Noodles Toss and Turn, Save Them):

### 1. **Romulus –**

Romulus expanded Rome's population in two ways: offering asylum on the Capitoline for outlaws and through taking the wives of the neighboring Sabine tribe ("the rape of the Sabines"). **Titus Tatius** led the Sabines to recover their wives, and captured the Capitoline Hill through the treachery of a Vestal Virgin named **Tarpeia**. Tarpeia betrayed the Romans by letting the Sabines in through the gates after being promised to receive what they "bore on their arms." Naturally she hoped for their golden bracelets, instead she was crushed to death between their shields. Her body was buried atop the cliff, giving it its name: the Tarpeian Rock. Later, Romans sentenced to execution might be thrown from this cliff on the Capitoline Hill. Romulus then co-ruled with Titus Tatius (Romulus on the Palatine, Tatius on the Capitoline).

Romulus establishes the Senate. After Romulus' death, he is deified as the god **Quirinus**, and Romans are sometimes referred to as Quirites from that basis. His wife Hersilia is deified as Hora.

### 2. **Numa Pompilius –**

Numa makes religious reforms, including the Flamines and the establishment of the Cult of Vesta (Vestal Virgins who tend the sacred fire of Rome), even though stories of Vestals are recorded earlier. He also established a 12-month calendar in place of a 10-month one. Numa is reported to have as his consort a water nymph named **Egeria**.

### 3. **Tullus Hostilius –**

Warrior king (~Hostilius was hostile) who destroys Alba Longa. This was the setting of the famous duel of the **Horatii and Curiatii**. The Horatii were three Roman brothers who were chosen to fight the Curiatii, three brothers from Alba Longa, as a way to decide the outcome of the war with less bloodshed. While the armies watched, two of the Horatii were killed and the third pretended to flee. When each of the three Curiatii singly followed him, the last of the Horatii turned and slew him. Rome was victorious. When Horatia, the sister of the Horatii, mourned the Curiatii, the remaining brother Horatius killed her. Tullus Hostilius also builds the Senate House in Rome, which has the full name *curia hostilia* (usually shortened to *curia*).

### 4. **Ancus Marcius –**

Ancus built the **Pons Sublicius** ("the wooden bridge"), which was the first bridge across the Tiber, where a distant "8<sup>th</sup> hill" of Rome sat, called the Janiculum. Legend also states that he started a settlement at Ostia, where the Tiber meets the Mediterranean. Ostia would become the chief port of Rome.

### 5. **Tarquinius Priscus –**

"Tarquin the Elder" was of Etruscan origin. The son of Demaratus, his real name was believed to be **Lucomio**. His wife was Tanaquil.

### 6. **Servius Tullius –**

Servius Tullius was possibly of Etruscan origin also, with the Etruscan name Mastarna. His mother Ocrisia had been a prisoner of war in the court of Tarquinius Priscus. He built the first major wall around Rome (“**Servian Wall**”). The cult of Diana was established on the Aventine hill during his reign. His daughter **Tullia** married Tarquinius Superbus, the son or grandson of Tarquinius Priscus. Tullia helped Tarquinius Superbus kill her father Servius Tullius, and then she rode over his body with a chariot on a road later called the Via Scelerata (“The wicked way”).

7. **Tarquinius Superbus –**

Tarquin the “Proud” was of Etruscan origin like his grandfather Tarquinius Superbus. He finished the temple of Jupiter Capitolinus on the Capitoline Hill and the Cloaca Maxima, Rome’s great sewer. In the temple were held the Sibylline Books, 3 books of sacred prophecy. He was originally offered all nine books by the Sibyl, but she burned three of them after he first refused her price, and three more when he refused again. He relents and buys the final three. These books were consulted in times of great crisis for centuries after. He was an arrogant king whose son **Sextus Tarquinius** abused royal power by taking **Lucretia** (“the rape of Lucretia”), the wife of a nobleman named **Collatinus**. Collatinus and his friend L. (Lucius) Junius **Brutus** overthrew Tarquin and establish the Republic as its first consuls.

## **THE 7 HILLS OF ROME**



## Republic (509 BCE – 27 BCE)

**Brutus** – Lucius Iunius Brutus pretends to be a slow-witted man with little leadership potential, but leaps into action after the rape of Lucretia, overthrows Tarquin and becomes Rome's first consul alongside Collatinus. Rome will have two elected consuls each year. Demonstrating his priorities, Brutus also had two of his executed for attempting to restore the monarchy under the Tarquins.

**Lars Porsenna** – Etruscan king who tried to capture Rome at beginning of Republic. His assault was thwarted by the bravery of Horatius at the **Pons Sublicius** (Sublician Bridge), which crosses the Tiber River (ca. 506 BCE).

**Horatius** – Horatius Cocles (“One-Eyed Horatio”) singlehandedly defended the Sublician Bridge from the onslaught of Lars Porsenna and the Etruscans, pushing the enemy back across the Tiber while he asked that the bridge behind him be destroyed. He swam the Tiber in his armor to return to the city rescued city (ca. 506 BCE).

**Mucius Scaevola** – Scaevola means “lefthanded” or “lefty”. Gaius Mucius was a Roman who went to persuade Porsenna that Rome would not surrender. He earned his nickname by holding his right hand in a flame in front of Porsenna to show him the resolve of Rome, losing his hand but winning the argument and convincing Porsenna.

**Cloelia** – Roman woman who was captured by Lars Porsenna, but escaped and swam across the Tiber or rode on horseback to return to Rome. She was handed back to Porsenna so that a treaty would not be broken by her escape, but he was so impressed by her feat that he sets her free.

**Castor and Pollux** – mythical twins who were the sons of Zeus and brothers of Helen of Troy. When the Romans were fighting the Latins at the **Battle of Lake Regillus** in 496 BCE, two young men of surpassing beauty appeared to the Roman general Postumius and swiftly charged the enemy, winning victory for Rome. Postumius built a Roman temple for them in commemoration.

**Coriolanus** – A Roman noble of the name Gaius Marcius who was expelled from Rome, but came back leading an army of the Volsci (neighboring tribe from town of Corioli) against Rome. Only his mother, **Veturia**, and wife, **Volumnia**, could save Rome by persuading him to turn back.

**Cincinnatus** – A Roman farmer who was called from his plow to be the Dictator of Rome during an invasion (by the Aequi in 458). A Roman Dictator took the place of the consuls and had supreme authority for a period of 6 months. Dictators were only called in times of severe crisis. After saving Rome, Cincinnatus returned to his plow and his simple life.

**Twelve Tables, and other laws** – The 5<sup>th</sup> century BCE is a time of great unrest between Roman patricians (aristocrats) and plebeians (commoners), who abandon the city (“the secession of the plebs”) on more than one occasion. A speech about cooperation between the “belly and the limbs” by Menenius Agrippa brings the plebeians back on one such occasion. The tribune Terentilius Harsa first requested a code of written laws in 462 BC. Bronze tablets of Roman law are inscribed in 450 and posted in the Forum for everyone, including plebeians, to see. They are written by a commission of ten men called the Decemviri (Decemviri Legibus Scribundis, “ten men who are to write the laws”), which is led by Appius Claudius. Appius Claudius abused his

power by trying to take the maiden Verginia, who killed herself instead. In 445 BC a law is passed (lex Canuleia) which legalizes marriage between patricians and plebeians, and states that the *concilium plebis* (plebeian assembly) can pass laws (plebiscita), with the approval of the more aristocratic *comitia centuriata*. The lex Hortensia of 287 BCE removed this approval restriction, further increasing the power of plebeians. The Sexto-Licinian law of 367 BCE is also significant in that it requires at least one of the annual consuls to be plebeian. Lucius Sextius became the first plebeian consul in 366 BC.

**Camillus** – known as “The Second Founder of Rome,” Camillus led the capture of the nearby town of Veii in 396 by tunneling under its walls.

**Brennus** – Chief of Gallic tribe that successfully defeats a Roman army at the **Allia River** and captures the city of Rome in 390. The Romans retreated to the “arx”, a citadel or fortress, of the Capitoline Hill in Rome. One night the hill was nearly captured by Gauls climbing up, but the sacred geese of Juno began to cackle, bringing the attention of Marcus Manlius. After his brave defense of the hill, he was called **Marcus Manlius Capitolinus**. Impatient, Brennus offered to leave if paid a ransom. When the Romans complained about false weights on the scale Brennus used to weigh the gold ransom, Brennus replied “vae victis” (“woe to the vanquished”, i.e. suffering to the defeated - you lost, don’t whine). Rome would not be captured by a foreign power again until 476 CE, almost 900 years later, and would be the bringer of vae victis to many conquered nations from that point on.

**Samnite Wars (1<sup>st</sup>: 343-341, 2<sup>nd</sup>: 327-304/303, 3<sup>rd</sup>: 298-290 BCE)** – The Samnites occupied central Italy and were the chief rivals for supremacy on the Italian peninsula. The 1<sup>st</sup> Samnite War was a minor conflict in the vicinity of Capua. The 2<sup>nd</sup> Samnite War started over a dispute at Neapolis (Naples). The Romans lost the most famous battle of the war at **Caudine Forks (321 BCE)**, where a Roman army was forced to march under the yoke (a sign of complete surrender). Rome suffered another disaster at Lautulae in 315 BC under Fabius Rullianus. However, with the help of a road built from Rome to Capua by Appius Claudius Caecus (“The Appian Way”), the Romans were victorious in the war. The 3<sup>rd</sup> Samnite War featured the heroism of Decius Mus at the battle of Sentinum in 295 BCE. The Samnites surrendered in 290 BCE and accepted status as Roman allies after all of their lands were annexed by Rome.

**Appius Claudius Caecus** – Appius Claudius “the Blind” (Caecus = Blind). Appius Claudius was a censor in 312 BCE. Two **censors** were elected every 5 years, and served terms of 18 months. They were responsible for editing the rolls of citizens (taking off, or censoring, anyone who didn’t meet their standards) as well as managing the construction of roads and aqueducts. Appius Claudius Caecus is most famous for a road and an aqueduct he began: the Via Appia and the Aqua Appia, in 312 BCE. The Via Appia connected Rome to Capua in the South, and was eventually extended to Brundisium. It was built to quickly move armies in the 2<sup>nd</sup> Samnite War and is still used today.

**Decius Mus** – was a Roman general who was told by a divine dream that the army which lost its general in the next day’s battle would be victorious. With the quality of self-sacrifice highly esteemed in the Republic, Decius led a headlong charge into the Samnites at the battle of Sentinum in 295 BCE. Decius Mus died in the charge, and Rome was indeed victorious in the battle and in the Third Samnite War.

End Samnite Wars

---

**Pyrrhus** – Mercenary from Epirus in Greece (~Pyrrhus from Epirus) hired by the Italian city of Tarentum to combat Rome. He reportedly once said “How easily I could conquer the world, had I the Romans for soldiers, or they me for king.” He won battles at Heraclea (280) and Asculum (279), but his victories come with huge losses of his own men. This is where the term “Pyrrhic victory” comes from (a victory which costs more than it is worth). His ambassador Cineas returned from the Roman senate remarking that it was an “assembly of kings.” Pyrrhus is defeated at Maleventum in 275 by the Roman general Curius Dentatus. Maleventum was called Beneventum by the Romans forever after. Fabricius, noted for his austerity and refusal to accept bribes, was the most famous Roman general to oppose Pyrrhus. Pyrrhus was the first enemy of Rome to use elephants against Rome, even before Hannibal. The Romans combated the elephants using fiery missiles to scare them.

**1st Punic War (264 - 241 BCE)** – conflict between Rome, the major power of Italy and the Northern Mediterranean versus Carthage, the major power of Africa (modern-day Tunis in Tunisia) and the Southern Mediterranean. Rome had a powerful land army. Carthage was a nation of shipping merchants and had a powerful navy. The Carthaginians originated from Phoenicia, from which the name Punic is derived. Conflict breaks out on the island of Sicily in 264, and escalates at the Sicilian town of Agrigentum in 262. Rome realizes it must build a navy to fight Carthage, and replicates a captured Carthaginian ship to build its first navy. The ship is a quinquereme, which has five banks of oars.

**Mamertines of Messana** – Campanian mercenaries calling themselves the men of Mars, took over the town of Messana on Sicily after abandoning their agreement to fight for the Syracusans. When Syracuse, the principal city of Sicily, fought to move them, the Mamertines appealed to Carthage for aid. The Carthaginians scared off the Syracusans, but then occupied the city more permanently. The Mamertines then appealed to Rome to help them get rid of the Carthaginians. After much debate, the Roman senate decides to intervene and soon takes control of Messana. The result is war with Carthage, as well as Syracuse.

**Duilius** – Roman admiral at Rome’s first major naval battle, the Battle of Mylae, in 260 BCE, during the first Punic War. The Romans surprise the Carthaginians with a device called the Corvus (“The Crow”), which is like a grappling hook at the end of a plank which is dropped onto the enemy ship. The corvus enabled the Romans to pull the ships together, send Roman soldiers to board the enemy ships, and essentially turn the battle into a land war at sea. Duilius wins Rome’s first ever naval victory at Mylae.

**Regulus** – Roman admiral who was captured by the Carthaginians during the 1<sup>st</sup> Punic War. He won the the Battle of **Cape Ecnomus** against the Carthaginian general Hasdrubal in 256 BCE. When he attacked Carthage in 255 BCE, however, the Carthaginians, under the command of the Spartan mercenary **Xanthippus**, defeated his army and captured Regulus himself at Bagradas Valley. He was set free so that he might negotiate a peace with the Roman Senate on behalf of the Carthaginians, under the condition that he must return to Carthage with a settlement acceptable to the Carthaginians. Upon returning to Rome, he convinced the Senate not to accept any such peace and willingly went back to Carthage to be executed, demonstrating Roman honor and resolve.

**Claudius Pulcher** – Roman admiral responsible for disastrous naval defeat at Drepana in 249 BCE. When the sacred chickens refused to eat before battle (a bad omen), he reportedly said “throw the

chickens into the sea; if they won't eat, let them drink!'. Ninety-three of 120 Roman ships were lost at Drepana.

**Lutatius Catulus** – Roman who defeats the Carthaginians at the **Battle of Aegates Islands**, ending the 1<sup>st</sup> Punic War. Rome occupies Sicily. Carthage retreats but rebuilds.

**Hamilcar Barca** – The most brilliant of the Carthaginian generals, whose name “Barca” meant blitz or lightning. Despite the success of Hamilcar in the 240s, the combination of the Battle of Aegates Islands (241 BCE) and changing leadership in Carthage led to what Hamilcar believed to be premature surrender to Rome when victory could still be achieved by Carthage. After the war, he focuses on building Carthaginian strength in Spain, which ultimately is the launching point of the Second Punic War. Barcelona is named after Hamilcar Barca. With him in Spain will be his son, Hannibal, who swears eternal hatred for Rome in return for the opportunity to join his father's military exploits. Hannibal will eventually rise to take his father's place.

#### End 1st Punic War

**2nd Punic War (218 - 202 BCE)** – conflict between Rome and Carthage this time breaks out in Spain, where Carthage moves North of the Ebro river to attack Saguntum, violating the Ebro River Treaty established in 226 BCE with Hasdrubal.

**Hannibal** – A Carthaginian now considered one of the greatest generals in all history, Hannibal is the son of **Hamilcar Barca**. Hamilcar fought against Rome in the 1<sup>st</sup> Punic War, and believed Carthage should have won. Holding young Hannibal above a fire, Hamilcar made his son swear eternal hatred to the Romans. The Spanish city of Barcelona is named after Hamilcar Barca. Hannibal is 28 when the war begins in 218. Significant events are as follows:

- After sacking the Spanish city of Saguntum in 219 (the first step of war), Hannibal shocks the Romans by swiftly crossing the Alps from Spain and Gaul into Italy. He brings 37 African elephants with him. Elephants are the tanks of ancient warfare.
- Hannibal defeats a Roman army led by Publius Cornelius Scipio (the father of Scipio Africanus, who saves his father in this battle) at the Ticinus River in 218, and then follows this victory with another at the Trebia River against Sempronius Longus in the same year.
- A frightened Rome sends a larger army under Flaminius to swiftly end the threat of Hannibal. The Roman army is considered to be the supreme force in the Mediterranean world. Despite being outnumbered, Hannibal traps and destroys this army of Flaminius at the **Battle of Lake Trasimene** in 217.
- Fearful for the city itself, Rome sends the largest army it has ever mustered, 80,000 men, including leading citizens, to stop the threat of Hannibal. “Hannibal ad portas” (“Hannibal at the gates!”) is a phrase used to evoke the greatest fears of the city. The Roman generals are Paulus and Varro. Hannibal is greatly outnumbered. The armies meet at **Battle of Cannae** in 216 BCE. Hannibal's army pretends to be weak in its center, drawing the charging Romans in, while his flanks surround them. 70,000 Romans die in battle, including Aemilius Paulus. It remains one of the most brilliant victories ever. This is the peak of Hannibal's success.

**Quintus Fabius Maximus Cunctator** – known as “The Delayer” and “The Shield of Rome”. After Rome's early catastrophic defeats to Hannibal, Fabius Maximus was made dictator of Rome. Instead of engaging Hannibal directly, he stayed close enough to harass him but never exposed the army to battle. This effectively slowed Hannibal's progress and made the conflict a

war of attrition – difficult for Hannibal because he was in enemy territory without steady supplies. The name “Cunctator” (“Delayer”) was given to Fabius in honor of his tactics.

**Marcellus** – known as “The Sword of Rome”. Marcellus was a general who fought aggressively against Hannibal during the 2<sup>nd</sup> Punic War, balancing the cautious tactics of Fabius Cunctator. He captured the city Syracuse in Sicily, despite the clever defenses of the Syracusan engineer **Archimedes**. Prior to the 2<sup>nd</sup> Punic War, Marcellus won the “Spolia Opima” (“richest spoils”), which could only be won by a general who defeated the opposing general in single combat. Marcellus was the third and final Roman to win the Spolia Opima, by defeating Viridomarus at Clastidium in 222 BC. Romulus had been first by defeating Acron. Cossus had been the second, defeating Tolumnius at Fidenae in 425 BC. Marcellus is killed in 208.

**Archimedes** – Syracusan scientist who engineers defenses for the city during the siege of Marcellus. He is also famous for having discovered some principals of buoyancy in his bath and shouted “*Eureka*” (I discovered it) as he ran naked through the streets of Syracuse. When the Roman soldiers come to kill Archimedes, he says “don’t disturb my circles,” referring to geometric patterns he was drawing in the sand before he dies.

**Hasdrubal** – Brother of Hannibal (other brother was Mago), who defended Spain while Hannibal invaded Italy. When a young Scipio (the future Scipio Africanus) invades Spain and captures Carthago Nova (New Carthage), Hasdrubal leaves for Italy to bring aid to Hannibal. He is cut off in Italy at the **Battle of the Metaurus River in 207 BCE** by the Roman general Claudius Nero. His great army is destroyed and he is killed. Hannibal sees the beginning of the end when Hasdrubal’s head is thrown into his camp a few days after the battle.

**Massinissa** – King of Numidia (region of North Africa) who aids Scipio Africanus in defeating Hannibal at Zama in 202, particularly through the use of Numidian cavalry. At the Battle of Great Plains in 203, he also helps Scipio defeat and capture Syphax.

**Scipio Africanus** – Son of the Scipio whom Hannibal defeated at the Ticinus River in 219, Publius Cornelius Scipio leads a Roman invasion into Africa to force Hannibal to leave Italy to defend Carthage. Scipio defeats Hannibal’s veteran but tired army at the **Battle of Zama in 202 BCE**. Scipio has studied Hannibal and uses the same tactics of Cannae to beat him, with the help of Massinissa’s Numidian cavalry. Zama decisively ends the 2<sup>nd</sup> Punic War, and Scipio is given the cognomen Africanus in honor of his victory. His full name is Publius Cornelius Scipio Africanus. His rival **Hannibal** stays for a period in Carthage but is then forced to flee. He is made an advisor/admiral for the Seleucid monarch **Antiochus the Great** in a war against Rome, but experiences limited success at sea. He finally commits suicide at the court of **Prusias** when the Romans are closing in on him.

## End 2<sup>nd</sup> Punic War

**Macedonian Wars:** After defeating Carthage for supremacy of the Western Mediterranean, Roman attention is drawn Eastward. The 2<sup>nd</sup> Century BCE witnesses the establishment of Roman power over Macedonia, Greece, and other parts of the Eastern Mediterranean.

**1<sup>st</sup> Macedonian War (215-205 BCE)** – Philip V of Macedon allied with Hannibal and attacked Rome to establish a second front. Rome brushes him off.

**2<sup>nd</sup> Macedonian War (200-196 BCE)** – Philip V shows aggression to weaker states in the Mediterranean, including Pergamum and its king Attalus I. Attalus appeals to Rome for help. A Roman army under Titus Quinctius **Flamininus** defeats Philip V at **Cynoscephalae** (“Dog’s Head”) in **197 BCE**. In 196 BCE, Flamininus proclaims freedom and independence for all Greek states in the name of the Roman Senate at the Isthmian Games in Corinth.

**3<sup>rd</sup> Macedonian War (171-167 BCE)** – After the death of Philip V, his eldest son **Perseus** rises to the throne and incites war with Rome. He is defeated at the **Battle of Pydna** in **168 BCE** by Lucius **Aemilius Paullus**. Rome abolishes the Macedonian monarchy and experiments with allowing Macedon to govern itself as four independent republics with restrictions on intermarriage, trade, etc.

**4<sup>th</sup> Macedonian War (149-148 BCE)** – An upstart named **Andriscus** pretends to be the son of the dead Perseus and leads additional resistance to Rome. When Rome defeats Andriscus, it annexes Macedon as the Roman province of Macedonia.

**Flamininus** – Titus Quinctius Flamininus is the victorious general at the Battle of Cynoscephalae (197 BCE) who declares freedom for all Greeks at the Isthmian Games (196 BCE).

#### End Macedonian Wars

---

**Antiochus the Great** – After the death of Alexander the Great in 323 BCE, his empire is divided into three parts: Macedon, ruled by the Antigonids; Egypt, ruled by the Ptolemies; and the old Persian empire (including modern Turkey, Syria, and Iraq) ruled by the Seleucids. Antiochus III (the Great) is a Seleucid monarch whose invasion of Greece leads to war with Rome between 192 and 189 BCE. He is defeated at **Thermopylae** (the same site as the Persian defeat of Spartans in 480 BCE) by the Romans under Glabrio in **191 BCE**. Antiochus also uses the refugee **Hannibal** as an advisor and admiral, but the great land general is largely ineffective commanding a navy. The 190 BCE **Battle of Myonessus** was the last notable Roman naval victory over a foreign enemy. Antiochus is finally defeated by armies under the command of **Scipio Africanus** and his brother **Lucius Cornelius Scipio** at the **Battle of Magnesia** in **190 BCE**. A peace treaty is signed at Apamea in 188 BCE.

**Cato the Elder** – Marcus Porcius Cato was Roman Censor who ended every speech *Carthago delenda est* (“Carthage must be destroyed”), in reference to Rome’s most hated enemy. Carthage received harsh terms after the war, but was allowed to survive. Carthage is destroyed completely in 146, at the conclusion of the 3<sup>rd</sup> Punic War (149-146). Cato is also known for his stern manner, high moral standards, and love of cabbage. He is also a “novus homo” (new man), the first of his family to reach great office.

**3rd Punic War (149 - 146 BCE)** – After Carthage finishes paying a 50 year indemnity following the 2<sup>nd</sup> Punic War, it makes a small violation of the treaty signed 5 decades earlier, and Rome decides to invade again. Rome’s old ally Masinissa knew the Carthaginians would not be able to defend themselves against his incursions without technically violating their treaty with Rome, but they eventually have no choice but to resist him by actively defending themselves. Rome takes this opportunity to attack.

**Scipio Aemilianus** – the adopted grandson of Scipio Africanus. Scipio Aemilianus leads the invasion of Africa and completely destroys Carthage in 146, salting the fields so that they can never again bear crops. Scipio reportedly weeps at the suffering of Carthaginians, not out of sympathy but rather out of a premonition of the same fate for Rome someday. In that same year (146), the city

of **Corinth** in Greece is captured by a Roman army led by **Mummius**, marking the final great conquests of their rivals in the East and West (Greece had been subdued after the 2<sup>nd</sup> Punic War, but Corinth represented the final resistance). Thirteen years later, in 133, Scipio Aemilianus leads the siege and capture of the Spanish town of **Numantia** (see below), the last stronghold of Spanish resistance. The most famous cousins of Scipio Aemilianus were the Gracchi brothers.

#### End 3<sup>rd</sup> Punic War

---

**Affairs in Spain** – After fighting Carthaginian forces in Spain, Rome slowly reduced general resistance there during the 2<sup>nd</sup> Century BCE.

**Viriathus** – A shepherd-turned-general who routinely defeats Roman forces with his force of Lusitanians (Lusitania is modern-day Portugal). After freeing a trapped Roman army of 50,000 men in return for a peace treaty, Rome bribes two traitors to slit Viriathus' throat.

**Numantia** – Spanish stronghold which is finally starved into submission in 133 BCE by Scipio Aemilianus. A governor of 137 BCE, **Tiberius Gracchus**, had made a successful peace with the town in exchange for permitting an army of 20,000 Roman soldiers live. Like the agreement with Viriathus, this one is treacherously broken by Rome. Numantia marks the last significant Spanish resistance to Rome, until the Roman general Sertorius leads Spanish forces against Rome in the 1<sup>st</sup> Century BCE.

#### End Affairs in Spain

---

**Attalus III of Pergamum** – Descendant of Attalus I who had solicited Roman aid against Philip V of Macedon, Attalus III is a Roman ally whose bequeaths the territory of Pergamum (in Asia Minor) in 133 BCE, increasing Rome's territory, sphere of influence, and wealth.

**Gracchi Brothers** – **Tiberius Gracchus** and **Gaius Gracchus** were two brothers who served as tribunes of the plebs, or common people. Their mother **Cornelia** was the daughter of Scipio Africanus, who had defeated Hannibal. Cornelia is held up as the example of the ideal Roman matron. She calls Tiberius and Gaius her "jewels". Ten **tribunes** are elected each year to represent the rights of the plebeians against the aristocracy. They have the unique power to veto any legislation. As tribunes, Tiberius (133) and Gaius (123-22) introduce radical and controversial reform legislation, particularly land reform to redistribute large estates, on behalf of the plebeians of Rome, and both are killed while in office. Both took the unusual steps of campaigning for a second year in office in order to retain the protected of tribunes by law; Gaius wins a second term but Tiberius is killed on election day of 132 BCE (by a mob of senators in the forum). One of Gaius' more controversial plans is to redevelop the area of Carthage as the colony of Iunonia. **Scipio Nasica** is directly responsible for Tiberius Gracchus' death, while the consul **Lucius Opimius** was most responsible for killing Gaius Gracchus. The death of Gaius Gracchus is prescribed by a supreme decree of the senate, called a *Senatus Consultum Ultimum*. These violent reactions within civil affairs, confrontations between the aristocracy and plebeians, and elevation of individuals above the power of the senate mark the beginning of a chaotic century in Rome, which will not subside until the pacification of Augustus and removal of Republican liberties.

**Jugurtha** – King of Numidia who wages war with Rome between 111 and 104 BCE. Jugurtha was a grandson of Massinissa and had fought for Scipio Aemilianus at Numantia, where he became

familiar with many leading Roman. One of Jugurtha's allies, his father-in-law Bocchus, the king of Mauretania, ultimately betrays Jugurtha by capturing him and turning him over to L. Cornelius Sulla, a young subordinate of the Roman general Marius.

**Marius** – serves under Scipio Aemilianus at Numantia, and goes on to be consul seven times, the first in 107 and the last in 86 BCE. Though he came from the small town of Arpinum with no previous family of consular rank (a new man, or *novus homo*), Marius steadily acquires power and marries into one of the noblest Roman families, the Julii Caesares. His wife is the aunt of C. Julius Caesar. He always resents nobility however, appealing to popular interests in politics and accepting soldiers whether they met the tradition property qualifications or not. As such, he becomes the chief leader of the Populares (party of the people) in his day. His military reforms also included reorganization of the legions. With the help of his quaestor Sulla, Marius defeats an African army led by Jugurtha in 106. He then is called to suppress the threat posed by the Gauls, who defeated a Roman army at the Battle of Arausio in 105 BCE. Marius defeats the Teutones at Aquae Sextiae in 102 BCE and the Cimbri at Vercellae in 101 BCE. The tribune Saturninus supports him, but Saturninus is killed in a riot in 100 BC and pelted to death by the roof tiles of the curia while he was imprisoned there. He wields great power in Rome, but loses a struggle for supremacy with Sulla. He returns to Rome and accepts his record seventh consulship in 86 BCE, but dies that same year, leaving no further resistance to Sulla.

**Sulla** – serves heroically under Marius in the Jugurthine War, most famously organizing the capture of Jugurtha himself. Sulla contends with Marius for the mandate to fight against Mithridates of Pontus. When the Senate gives the command to Sulla, he makes sure it isn't transferred to Marius by leading an army on the city itself – he is the first Roman general ever to lead a Roman army to occupy Rome itself. As Dictator, he makes proscription lists (proscribes his enemies), which means that he lists the people he wants executed without any trial. All of this sets a very bad precedent, and the discipline of the Republic continues to wind away. One of his best generals is a young man named Gnaeus Pompeius, who will be a leading general after Sulla's death – Pompey the Great. When Sulla meets a teenage Julius Caesar, he remarks "I see in him many a Marius". Following the examples of Marius and Sulla, Caesar and Pompey will recreate the pair's alliance and conflict on an even larger scale in their own generation.

**Social War** – Livius Drusus the Younger, tribune of 91 BC, promotes citizenship for the Latin allies. His assassination in 91 ignites a war between Rome and her allies. A Samnite general named Mutilus figures prominently. The lex Julia of 90 BC extends many rights to the allies helps bring the end of the war.

**Sertorius** – gifted commander who served with Marius against Jugurtha and ran a Spanish campaign of resistance against the government of Sulla his followers from 82 to 73 BCE. He was ultimately assassinated by Perperna after being hunted down by an army of Pompey.

**Mithridates VI of Pontus** – Ruler of Asia Minor who intends to overthrow Roman influence in the Eastern Mediterranean. There are three Mithridatic Wars between 87 and 63 BCE, in which the great generals Sulla, Lucullus and Pompey each fight with the King of Pontus. Mithridates dies in 63 BCE.

**Lucullus** – Roman general who campaigned against Mithridates successfully for eight years before his army mutinied and his command was handed over to Pompey. He brought the cherry tree from the East to Italy, and the botanical name of the cherry tree today is Lucullus.

**Spartacus** – Slave in a Capua gladiatorial school who leads a revolt of other gladiators and slaves against Rome between the years 73 and 71. Crassus ultimately puts down this rebellion in 71. Six thousand of the rebellious slaves are crucified along the Appian Way by Pompey the Great.

**Crassus** – the wealthiest man in Rome of his day, who unites with Caesar and Pompey to form the “**First Triumvirate**” in 60 BCE. He is killed in **53 BCE** at **Carrhae** in Parthia (Middle East). Surenas leads the Parthians that defeat him.

**Pompey** – Gnaeus Pompeius Magnus (Pompey the Great) was a powerful Roman general who allied with Caesar and Crassus as part of the 1<sup>st</sup> Triumvirate (formed in 60 BCE) and then fought with Caesar for the supreme power in Rome. In his early career he served Sulla against Sertorius and others, and was also given a commission to hunt down pirates who were devastating travel and trade in the Mediterranean (which he accomplished in 3 months). He and Crassus share the consulship in 70 and 55 BCE. In 55, he builds Rome’s first permanent theater. He has the unusual distinction of being sole consul in 52 BCE. Like Sulla, whom he had served, Pompey was a member of the Optimates party (the elite senatorial party), while Caesar was a member of the Populares (the peoples’ party), like Marius. Pompey was sole consul of Rome (there are normally two consuls) in 52. He was defeated by Caesar in the battle of Pharsalus in 48 BCE and died while escaping.

**Cicero** (106 – 43 BCE) – was the finest orator (public speaker) in Roman history. Marcus Tullius Cicero was reached the consulship in 63 BCE as a “*novus homo*” (“new man”), which meant no one from his family had served in public office before. Like another famous *novus homo*, Marius, Cicero also came from the town of Arpinum. “Cicero” means “chickpea.” He was a successful attorney whose court arguments are read still today. He was also a brilliant philosopher. As consul in 63, he stops the conspiracy of Catiline (the Catilinarian Conspiracy). Caesar and Cato the Younger hotly debate whether the conspirators should be executed. After the execution of the conspirators, Cicero simply states “*vixerunt*” (they have lived). Later he is banished from Rome by his political enemies, led by the tribune Clodius, for having put the conspirators to death without trial. Even after returning to Rome, he retires from public life. After the death of Caesar, Cicero delivers critical speeches against Mark Antony called the Philippics (modeled on speeches made by the Greek Demosthenes against Philip of Macedon, the father of Alexander the Great). When the 2<sup>nd</sup> Triumvirate was formed, Antony put Cicero first on his proscription list, and Cicero was executed on December 7, 43 BCE, in Formiae. His hand and head were hung on the rostra, or public speaking platform in the Forum, where he had delivered many speeches. Rostra means “prows of ships,” and prows of captured ships from Antium formed the speaking platform itself. It also means the beak of a bird, which resemble the prows of ships.

**Catiline** – As consul of 63 BCE, Cicero uncovers a plot to overthrow the government led by Catiline. He reports the plot in a series of dramatic speeches before the Senate, and ultimately orders Catiline and the other conspirators to be executed.

**Cato the Younger** – Great-grandson of Cato the Elder who shares his ancestor’s famous austerity and republican virtue, called “the conscience of Rome”. Cato the Elder routinely opposes Julius Caesar, and fights for the death penalty for Catiline and his conspirators despite Caesar’s opposition. He governs Utica in North Africa during a period of the Civil Wars, earning the agnomen *Uticensis* for his fair administration. He fights Caesar at the Battle of Thapsus (46 BC)

in North Africa, and commits suicide after being defeated rather than accept a pardon from Caesar.

**Clodius** – Publius Clodius Pulcher is a Roman politician well known for several scandalous episodes. In 62 BCE, there is a celebration of the Bona Dea festival at Julius Caesar's home. Only women are allowed at this gathering. Clodius, suspected of having an affair with Caesar's second wife Pompeia, enters the festivities disguised as a woman but is caught. Caesar divorces his wife over the scandal, saying famously that "Caesar's wife must be above suspicion." At Caesar's bidding, Clodius arranges to have Cicero banished from Rome in 58 BCE for overstepping his power as Consul of 63 when he executed Catiline. Clodius was also responsible for the first free distribution of grain to the Roman populace. Clodius is murdered in 52 BCE by Milo, after which his clients among the plebs burned the senate house as his funeral pyre.

## **Gaius Julius Caesar (100-44 BCE) –**

### *Early career:*

- Kidnapped by pirates as a young man; promises to return and crucify his captors after ransom; makes good on his promise
- Serves as an **Aedile (manager of public entertainment)** in 68. He uses this opportunity to become more popular among the people at the expense of the state.
- Caesar serves as **Quaestor (treasurer)** in 65, **Praetor (judge)** in 62 and as **Consul (chief executive and general)** for the first time in 59. This is the standard order of offices, called the "**Cursus Honorum**" ("**Course of Offices**"). Each office term lasts one year, and there must be three years between serving in each office. There are two consuls elected each year, who alternate control each day. Caesar's co-consul in 59, named Bibulus, was so overshadowed that their administration is jokingly referred to as "the consulship of Julius and Caesar". Bibulus does earn Caesar's enmity by vetoing his agrarian bill. Afterwards, Bibulus shuts himself in his house and no longer participated at all. Caesar was also appointed **Pontifex Maximus (chief priest)** in 63, which was more ceremonial than administrative.
- In 60 BCE, joins the "First Triumvirate", a group of three men who will dominate Roman political affairs. The three men are Caesar, Pompey and Crassus. This union propels Caesar to the consulship in 59 BCE and the proconsulship (governorship of a province following one's year as consul) of Cisalpine Gaul.

### *Gallic Wars:*

- As a proconsul, Caesar is assigned to Cisalpine Gaul (the part of Gaul south of the Alps), Caesar launches a massive invasion of all of Gaul, including the vast area north of the Alps (modern France), in 58 BCE.
- Caesar invades Gallia, Britannia, and Germania. The campaign lasts 7 years. He writes of it in his famous "Commentaries on the Gallic Wars". The Gauls, led by **Vercingetorix**, are defeated in the siege of **Alesia** (near modern Paris) in **52 BCE**.

### *Civil Wars:*

- In 49 BCE Caesar leads his veteran army south across the Rubicon River, which forms the boundary Cisalpine Gaul and Italy. A general is not allowed to lead an army into Italy without the Senate's permission, so this is considered a treasonous invasion. He knows he will not be able to turn back politically once he crosses, and states "*alea iacta est*" (the die is cast).
- Since Crassus had died, Pompey (known as Pompey Magnus, or Pompey the Great), has been the leading figure within Rome itself. He fears Caesar's advance, and flees with his own armies.

- Pompey and Caesar clash in **48 BCE** at the **Battle of Pharsalus**, in Greece. Caesar wins decisively. Pompey is murdered when he flees. Grievous over the death of so many good Romans, Caesar exclaims “*hoc voluerunt*” (they wanted this).
- Caesar follows up his defeat of Pompey with victories at Zela, Thapsus and Munda in the following years to quell other resistance. After annihilating the forces of Pharnaces at Zela (in Asia Minor, modern-day Turkey) in 47, Caesar stated “*Veni, Vidi, Vici*”. Thapsus (in Africa) in 46 saw the defeat of Pompey’s sons and Cato the Younger. At Munda (Spain) in 45, he defeated the last followers of Pompey.

*Final Years:*

- Caesar returns to Rome and is named Dictator for life. Dictators were normally allowed serve no more than six months. Some believed Caesar was behaving like a king. **Brutus** and **Cassius** lead a conspiracy to assassinate Caesar on March 15, 44 BCE. This date was known as the Ides of March (the Ides were the 15<sup>th</sup> day of March, May, July and October, and the 13<sup>th</sup> day of each other month). Shakespeare gives us his last words as “et tu, Brute?” (and you, Brutus?, even you Brutus?) to his supposed friend Brutus. Brutus was also the descendant of the L. Iunius Brutus who killed Tarquin the Proud, Rome’s last king, in 509.
- His first wife, **Cornelia**, gives him his only child: Julia. Caesar divorces his second wife, **Pompeia** (Pompey’s daughter), after the Bona Dea scandal. The name of Caesar’s last wife is **Calpurnia**. He has no legitimate sons. Through his will, he adopts his great-nephew Octavian as his son and heir.
- Caesar is successful in other reforms, including the correction of the calendar, which became the Julian calendar (Pope Gregory later made some minor modifications to this, from which we have the Gregorian calendar).

**Brutus (Marcus Iunius Brutus)** – a descendant of the first consul of Rome, Brutus is a follower of Caesar (believed by some to be Caesar’s illegitimate son), who later plots conspires with Gaius **Cassius** Longinus to assassinate Caesar on the Ides of March, 44 BCE in the Theater of Pompey. The two men later fight Antony and Octavian at the Battle of Philippi in 42 BCE. Their armies are defeated and Brutus commits suicide.

**Mark Antony (Marcus Antonius)** – Antony had been Caesar’s colleague in Rome, and after Caesar’s death, Mark Antony joined Octavian to defeat against the forces of the assassins Brutus and Cassius at the **Battle of Philippi** in **42 BCE**. He was a member of the **2<sup>nd</sup> Triumvirate**, consisting of **Mark Antony**, **Marcus Lepidus**, and **Gaius Octavius Caesar (Octavian)**, later Augustus), formed in 43 BCE at Bononia and legally recognized for 5 years by the Lex Titia. He then fought Octavian for control of everything. While Antony is away in the East in 40 BCE, his wife Fulvia and brother Lucius are captured in the siege of **Perusia** in Italy. Octavian defeated the forces of Antony and his Egyptian wife Cleopatra at the naval battle of **Actium**, near Greece, in 31 BCE. Pursued by Octavian to Egypt (30 BCE), Antony committed suicide. The long period of Roman Civil Wars were over. So was the Republic.

**Octavian (later to become Augustus, see below)** (63 BCE – 14 CE) – Octavian was the great-nephew of Julius Caesar and adopted as a son through Caesar’s will. Supported by Cicero’s advocacy, he follows the consuls Hirtius and Pansa to rescue Decimus Brutus, who was under siege from Antony at **Mutina** in 43 BCE. Hirtius and Pansa are killed, and Octavian returns to take power in Rome. He first worked with Antony to defeat Brutus and Cassius at Philippi in 42 BCE, and then worked with Antony and Lepidus in the 2<sup>nd</sup> Triumvirate, formed in 43 BCE. Octavian squeezes Lepidus out, defeats Sextus Pompey (the son of Pompey the Great) at **Naulochus** in 36 BCE, and focuses on defeating Antony and his Egyptian wife Cleopatra (Antony was still married to Octavian’s sister Octavia in Rome, and would be the ancestor of Roman emperors through their

children). With the help of his general Agrippa, Octavian defeats Antony at the naval **Battle of Actium** in **31 BCE**. He has no more rivals to power. The period of the empire, or principate, will begin in 27 BCE.

## The Empire (27 BCE – 476 CE)

The empire, or principate, is characterized by the rule of one man – the emperor, or princeps. Beginning with Diocletian, it is considered a “dominate” rather than a “principate.” While the senate still functions, it is merely an advisory and administrative body which assists the emperor in his rule. Consuls are appointed by the emperor, who is often one of the two consuls for any year. Again, they have no real authority beyond the commands of the emperor.

### The Julio-Claudian Emperors (5 emperors, 27 BCE – 68 CE)

A combination of the intermarried Julian (related to Julius Caesar) and Claudian families, this is the first dynasty of Roman emperors. Succession is always in the family, until Nero doesn't provide a suitable heir. While some show capable leadership at times, particularly Augustus throughout his reign, others behave in ways that are very eccentric or perhaps insane.

**Augustus (first known as Octavian)** (emperor from 27 BCE - 14 CE) – Some historians argue the true start date of the empire is 31 BCE, since Augustus faced no rivals after defeating Antony at Actium in 31 BCE. Augustus' reign marked the beginning of the “Pax Romana” (“Roman Peace”), a period of relative stability throughout the empire until the death of Marcus Aurelius in 180 CE. Memorable points of his reign:

- Officially named Augustus and given imperium (“power”) for 10 years by the senate in 27 BCE.
- The Roman legionary standards lost by Crassus in 53 at Carrhae are returned to Rome.
- The Ara Pacis (Altar of Peace) is dedicated in Rome in 9 BCE.
- His chief lieutenant, Agrippa, builds the Pantheon. The Pantheon as we now see it is a renovation of Agrippa's building by Hadrian, but still displays Agrippa's name. Agrippa had played a key role in helping Augustus win at Actium in 31.
- The double-doors of the Temple of Janus, closed only in times of peace (hardly ever) were closed during part of Augustus' reign for only the second time in Roman history.
- Augustus was responsible for many social and government reforms, as well as building programs. He supposedly said, “I found Rome a city of brick, and left it a city of marble.” His social reforms aim at restoring traditional Roman family values. He exiles the great poet Ovid for some scandalous poetry; Ovid cites the reason of his banishment as “*carmen et error*” (a poem and a mistake).
- Known for saying “*festina lente*” (make haste slowly) and, before he dies, “*acta est fabula*” (the story is finished)
- In 9 CE, three legions led by the Roman general Varus were completely destroyed by Germans under Arminius in the Teutoburg Forest. The legionary standards, which featured an eagle decoration, were captured. Augustus, repeatedly shouted to himself, “Quintilius Varus, where are my eagles?!” (“*Vare, redde mi legiones*” – Varus give me back my legions)
- By his first wife, Scribonia, Augustus has his only child, a daughter named Julia. He is obsessed with finding a proper male heir. Julia first marries Augustus' nephew Marcellus, who is praised by Vergil and believed to have a bright future, but dies young in 23 BC. She then marries Augustus' chief lieutenant Agrippa, by whom she has five children, including Gaius Caesar and Lucius Caesar, who both die young, and Agrippina the Elder. Her third husband is the stepson of Augustus, Tiberius, by whom she has no children and to whom she is completely unfaithful. Augustus eventually exiles her for her loose morals and lascivious behavior. Though Julia's daughter Agrippina will become the mother of Caligula (through her marriage to Tiberius' nephew Germanicus) and grandmother of Nero, she provides no true near-term heir for Augustus.

- Augustus most likely dies of old age. His second wife is Livia. Her son Tiberius succeeds Augustus. Her other son, Drusus dies early but not before his son Germanicus is born. Germanicus recovers the eagles of Varus after Augustus' death, and is the father of Caligula and grandfather of Nero.
- Augustus became the first deified emperor during the reign of Tiberius.

**Tiberius (emperor 14 - 37)** – Augustus's stepson (son of Livia by her first marriage), whom Augustus adopted. The oldest of the Julio-Claudians when he ascended the throne, Tiberius was a suspicious ruler who eventually left Rome to rule from his palace on the island of Capri. Unpopular at times, he supposedly said "*Oderint dum probent*" ("Let them hate, so long as they approve"). His evil advisor Sejanus wields great influence by which many innocent men are executed for treason, until Tiberius has Sejanus himself executed for treason in 31. Tiberius' sister-in-law, Antonia (the wife of Drusus, daughter of Antony and Octavia), reveals the intrigues of Sejanus to him. Macro becomes the new praetorian prefect. Most likely Tiberius died of old age, though some suggest Macro smothers him in his bedsheets to ensure the succession of Caligula.

**Caligula (emperor 37 - 41)** – His name means literally "Little Boot," a nickname given to him as a little boy by the soldiers under the command of his father, the great general Germanicus (grandson of Livia, nephew of Tiberius). Caligula behaved strangely as an emperor, even naming his horse Incitatus as a Senator. He was assassinated by Cassius Chaerea, a member of the praetorian guard (palace guards).

**Claudius (emperor 41 - 54)** – Believed to be a stuttering fool as a young man, Claudius was found hiding behind a curtain by palace guards after Caligula's assassination, and was declared emperor by these guards. Britain was invaded (in 43) and conquered during his reign. Freedmen (former slaves) became his chief advisors. His third wife, Messalina, was executed for marrying another and conspiring against him. His fourth wife, Agrippina the Younger, brought a son by her first marriage. This son, Nero, was betrothed to Claudius' daughter Octavia, and succeeded Claudius when he died (most likely of natural causes, though some suggested Agrippina poisoned him with a bowl of poisoned mushrooms). Claudius's son Britannicus (by Messalina) was disposed of by Nero after he ascended the throne.

**Nero (emperor 54 - 68)** – The youngest of the Julio-Claudians when he ascended the throne, Nero was an exceptional emperor for his first 5 years. His teachers included the great Stoic philosopher Seneca, and his mother Agrippina the Younger wielded great influence. Then he dissolved into a life of reckless vanity and destruction. Some significant events include the following:

- Nero ordered the murder of his rival Britannicus, the young son of Claudius and Messalina.
- He also had his wife Octavia (the daughter of Claudius) put to death.
- Nero ordered the assassination of his mother Agrippina the Younger, though she escaped several attempts. For instance, he had a boat prepared to collapse so that she would drown at sea as if by accident. When it began to sink, one of Agrippina's servants shouted for help, pretending to be Agrippina. The real Agrippina watched as this servant was beaten, and swam to shore herself despite her age. Later, she was simply beaten to death by the admiral of Nero's fleet, Anicetus.
- Alarmed by his pupil's life and fearing for his own, Seneca took his own life in 65.
- Nero was notorious for his persecution of the Christians, executing many followers of the emerging faith.
- A great fire swept through Rome in 64. Many believed Nero set the fire in order to clear space for the palatial residence (the **Domus Aurea**, or golden house) which he soon built.

- After his death, the space where he placed a huge lake in a palace garden became the site of the Colosseum. It was rumored that Nero fiddled or sang while Rome burned.
- Nero believed himself to be a great actor and musical performer, and made a concert tour of Greece in 66 to face the best competition. Naturally, he always won first place.
  - During his reign was the revolt of Boudicca (or Boadicea) in Britannia
  - Vindex led a revolt in Gaul against Nero in 68, beginning the erosion of his power. It was put down by Verginius Rufus. A Roman general named Galba bribed the praetorian guards to desert Nero. Seeing the writing on the wall, Nero asked one of his servants to plunge a sword into him.
  - His last words: “*Qualis artifex pereo*” (“What an artist dies in me!”).

## Year of the Four Emperors (69 CE)

Nero has no obvious successor, and generals of Roman armies across the empire compete in battle to decide who will rule. Supreme authority rests in four different hands during the year, with continuous war, featuring two separate battles at Cremona in Italy. Vespasian ends up the final winner.

**Galba** (emperor 68 - 69)

**Otho** (emperor 69) – defeated and killed by Vitellius’ generals Caecina & Valens at the **First Battle of Cremona/Bedriacum**.

**Vitellius** (emperor 69) – defeated by Vespasian’s general Antonius Primus at the **Second Battle of Cremona/Bedriacum**.

**Vespasian** (emperor 69 - 79) – captures Rome through his general Antonius Primus and begins the Flavian dynasty; see below

## The Flavian Emperors (69 – 96 CE)

The Flavian Dynasty (after their family nomen, Flavius) had a relatively stable rule after the chaos of 69.

**Vespasian** (emperor 69 -79) – listed above also; the father of Titus and Domitian. In reference to the deification of the earlier Julio-Claudians, said on his deathbed “*Vae, puto deus fio*” (“Alas, I think that I am becoming a god”).

**Titus** (emperor 79 - 81) – showed great promise, but died young of natural causes. Had put down the Jewish rebellion at Jerusalem and Masada while Vespasian was emperor, which is commemorated by the Arch of Titus in Rome. There are two significant events during Titus’s short reign:

- **August 24, 79 CE:** Mt. Vesuvius erupts, burying Pompeii and Herculaneum.
- **80 CE:** The Flavian amphitheater, named after this dynasty, is finished and dedicated. It is also known as the Colosseum, because of its size and the famous Colossus-like statue (formerly of Nero, now with the face of the sun god Helios) which stands just outside of it. The Colosseum will be a premiere attraction in Rome from then until today.

**Domitian** (emperor 81 - 96) – suspicious and tyrannical, he is betrayed by his wife (Domitia) and murdered by his butler (Stephanus). He liked to be called “*dominus et deus*”.

## The Five Good Emperors (96 – 180 CE)

The rule of the five good emperors marks one of the most stable and prosperous periods of Roman history – a so-called Golden Age of the Roman Empire. These emperors are not succeeded by their natural sons (except Marcus Aurelius), but instead pick the best-suited potential rulers and groom them as successors.

**Nerva** (emperor 96 - 98) – The first emperor appointed by the Senate. When he died he was the last person buried in the **Mausoleum of Augustus**.

**Trajan** (emperor 98 - 117) – The first emperor of provincial origins (born in Spain), Trajan believes in expansion of the empire, and grows the empire to its greatest ever territorial expanse in 117. He is called “*optimus princeps*”. His conquest of Dacia is commemorated in “Trajan’s column”, in which relief sculptures telling the story of the Dacian war spiral up a tall column. It is still in Rome today.

**Hadrian** (emperor 117 – 138) – Does not share Trajan’s enthusiasm for expansion and pulls back some of the empire’s farthest defensive lines, most famously constructing “Hadrian’s Wall” across the width of Britannia to mark the Roman border. The wall still stands in northern England. He also faces a revolt under the Moorish cavalry commander Lusius Quietus in 118. His wife is Sabina.

**Antoninus Pius** (emperor 138 - 161) – most famous for constructing the “Antonine Wall” just north of Hadrian’s wall in Britain.

**Marcus Aurelius** (emperor 161 - 180) – A Stoic philosopher whose book, *Meditations*, is still read today. He shared his throne for eight years with Lucius Verus. His wife is Faustina. He spends of his reign at war against the Parthians, the Quadi and Marcomanni. He dies in Vindobona (modern Vienna) in 180. His last words were “Go to the rising sun; my sun is setting.” The revolt of Asian governor Avidius Cassius occurs in his reign. Unlike his predecessors, he is succeeded by his son Commodus rather than the most worthy individual.

## The Decline of the Roman Empire

The ascent of Commodus, marks the end of the reign of the Five Good Emperors and the beginning of the fall of the Roman empire. The quality of rulers and stability of rule suffers until finally Rome is invaded by Barbarians in 476 CE, and the empire – at least in the West – is finished.

Highlights:

**Commodus** (emperor 180 - 192) – Completely unlike his father, Commodus is a disturbed young man who thought himself a reincarnation of Heracles. At one point he changed the name of Rome to *Colonia Commodiana*. His sister Lucilla unsuccessfully conspires to kill him in 185, but is ultimately strangled in his bath by a servant working with conspirators including his ex-mistress Marcia and the praetorian prefect Laetus.

**Pertinax** (emperor 193) – Pertinax succeeds Commodus, but his reign is cut short when he runs out of funds to pay the soldiers.

**Didius Julianus** (emperor **193**) – Didius Iulianus buys the imperial throne at an auction (outbidding Sulpicianus), but is only able to maintain control briefly.

**Septimius Severus** (emperor **193 - 211**) – Septimius Severus is a capable emperor whose military achievements are commemorated by an arch in the Roman Forum. His wife is Julia Domna; they are the parents of Caracalla and Geta.

**Caracalla** (emperor **211 – 217**) – The eldest son of Septimius Severus, Caracalla is famed for killing his brother **Geta** as they struggled for the throne. He also gives citizenship to all free inhabitants of the Roman Empire in 212.

**Macrinus** (emperor **217 – 218**) – First emperor of equestrian origin

**Elagabalus** (emperor **218 – 222**) – grandson of Julia Maesa (sister of Julia Domna), Elagabalus introduces the worship of a sun god from Emesa in Syria

**Severus Alexander** (emperor **222 – 235**) –

**238 AD** – The year of the six emperors: Maximinus Thrax (235-238), Gordian I, Gordian II, Balbinus, Pupienus, Gordian III (238-244). Gordian I and his son Gordian II are promoted by aristocrats in Africa.

**Philip the Arab** (emperor **244 -249**) – rules during the celebration of Rome's 1,000<sup>th</sup> anniversary

**Decius** (emperor **249 -251**) – first emperor to prosecute the Christians

**Valerian** (emperor **253 - 260**) – first emperor captured by the enemy. He is captured at Edessa and finishes his life as a prisoner of the Persian king **Shapur**.

**Gallienus** (emperor **253 - 268**) – son of Valerian who rules as co-emperor in West while Valerian attacks East. He enjoys teachings of Plotinus, and his wife Salonina attends lectures with him. He wins a major victory against the Goths at the battle of Naissus in 268, though the credit was given by some to his chief general Claudius (future Gothicus) and cavalry commander Aurelian. He dies while suppressing a rebellion under **Aureolus** at Mediolanum.

**Claudius Gothicus** (emperor **268 - 270**) – barbarian by birth who rose to become leading commander under Gallienus and was suspected by some of orchestrating Gallienus' death. Won the name "Gothicus" through leading the winning forces at Naissus in 268. Also routed the Alamanni at the battle of Lake Benacus in late 268. Died of plague in early 270.

**Aurelian** (emperor **270 – 275**) – Aurelian built the greatest wall around Rome ("The Aurelian Wall") since the king Servius Tullius built the Servian Wall. Aurelian also put down the rebellion of **Queen Zenobia** of Palmyra, ruling with her infant son **Vaballathus** (after the murder of her husband **Odenaethus**, who had been loyal to Rome). **Tetricus**, the defeated ruler of the Gallic empire, was paraded through Rome with Zenobia in Aurelian's triumph. He is called *restitutor orbis* ("restorer of the world") for defeating Tetricus, *resitutor orientis* ("restorer of the east") for defeating Zenobia, and *manus ad ferrum* ("hand on steel") for his strict discipline.

**Diocletian** (emperor **284 - 305**) – Diocletian was a strong emperor who restored order after a period of chaos. Diocletian instituted the “tetrarchy” (rule of four), in which the management of the Eastern and Western Empire were divided between two emperors who each had a “Caesar” to be his assistant and successor. His co-Augustus was **Maximian**. Though he became emperor in 284, Diocletian did not visit Rome until 303. In 305, Diocletian abdicated (gave up his power and retired), becoming the only Roman emperor to abdicate during his rule and not die in office. Without Diocletian’s leadership, the balance of the tetrarchy becomes more fragile, and conflict soon arises.

**Constantine** (emperor **306 - 337**) – Constantine was the son of one of the first Caesars in Diocletian’s tetrarchy (**Constantius**). Constantine eliminated his rival, **Maxentius**, in 312 at the Battle of the Milvian Bridge outside Rome. The most significant elements of his reign are as follows:

- Constantine is the first Christian emperor, and makes Christianity the official religion of the empire. He reports seeing the Christian symbol of a cross before the Battle of Milvian Bridge, and the words “in this sign you will conquer” (different versions in Latin: “*in hoc signo vinces*”). After his victory, his religious conversion is complete.
- Issues the Edict of Milan in 313 recognizing Christianity.
- Becomes sole emperor after defeating his last rival, **Licinius**, in 324 at the Battle of Chrysopolis.
- Constantine moves the official capital of the empire from the city of Rome to the city of Byzantium, renamed Constantinople. It is modern-day Istanbul. The Empire is officially divided into Eastern and Western empires after Constantine, in 364.

**Julian** (emperor 363-364) – the member of Constantine’s dynasty. Known as “the apostate” for trying to restore pagan worship. His successor **Jovian** immediately reverses his changes.

**Valens** (emperor 364-378) – first emperor captured in battle. Captured by the Goths, led by **Fritigern** at the Battle of Adrianople in 378. Beaten, skinned, dyed purple and stuffed.

**Theodosius** (379-395) – last emperor to rule the united empire. Banned pagan worship and closed all pagan temples in 391. Abolished the Olympic Games in 393. Massacred a crown in Thessalonica to avenge the murder of a general. Confided in **Ambrose**, the Bishop of Milan.

**Honorius** (395-423) – one of the sons of Theodosius who ruled the Western Empire. His brother **Arcadius** ruled in the East until 408. Stilicho, a half-vandal soldier, serves as a regent for Honorius until the emperor eventually becomes suspicious of Stilicho and has him beheaded. The Visigothic chieftain **Alaric** sacks Rome in 410, forcing Honorius to flee to Ravenna, his new capital.

**Romulus Augustulus** (emperor **475 - 476**) – last emperor of Western Roman empire, who is in power when German tribes under **Odoacer** sack the city for good. His name combines that of Rome’s first king and first emperor. The Eastern Roman Empire, with its capital at Constantinople, survives until 1,453.